

Websites have a front end and the back end that are intricately connected by some plugins, servers, bots and service providers. The framework gets even more complex when we talk about e-commerce websites like Amazon, Craigslist and eBay.

E-commerce websites use an API to connect buyers to product catalogue web pages directly with a global database that shares detailed information about the products you buy and sell.

Websites can use this type of API to display brand images, product descriptions, detailed product specifications, and full product titles directly from a global database of products. This allows them to populate a product catalogue content using an information API automatically. But this barely scratches the surface of what APIs can do.

Diving deeper into APIs

Airbnb, PayPal, Alibaba and Uber use it. It doesn't matter what they call it. An Application Programming Interface (API) is a set of algorithms that manage large-scale data and open up new business opportunities.

In layman terms, APIs extract personal information from consumers. They're algorithms with storage capabilities for personal information about users and their behaviour when they interact with a platform or a mobile application. This can include dates of birth, personal tastes, interests, consumption or movement patterns on the website. This data is used to improve services, products or even to create new businesses.

Two perfect examples of this use are Uber that calculates the best drivers and vehicles for you based on your previous rides and preferences, and Airbnb, that connects travellers with the temporary haven in a dream destination on many parameters.

Even jewellery retailer BaubleBar has made an art out of using social media trust signals, such as Instagram photo feeds of customers wearing their jewellery to give shoppers more confidence in buying products from them.

Retailers are also empowered by APIs to stream social media feeds directly to their website and product pages. Widgets on product catalogue platforms that allow you to show recent Twitter comments, for example, are powered behind-the-scenes by the Twitter API.

Closing down the search gap

Providing advanced search features on websites is one way that buyers can